

LOW-CODE APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT

Experiment Report

Setting Up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

A hands-on walkthrough of account setup, platform architecture, and the Develop • Deploy • Manage workflow



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Introduction

- Zoho Creator is a low-code platform that lets teams build business applications through drag-and-drop tools and built-in AI support rather than traditional hand-coding.
- This report captures a guided, hands-on tour of the Zoho Creator account setup, covering its three core functional areas: Develop, Deploy, and Manage.
- Every section below pairs a screenshot from the platform with a brief, plain-language note on what that feature does and where it sits in the application lifecycle.

Platform Architecture Overview

- Zoho Creator follows a layered, low-code architecture that runs from user access all the way down to deployment.
- **Access Layer:** covers the entry points into the platform — Web Browser, Mobile App (iOS/Android), Customer/Partner Portal, Microservices/API Clients, and Embedded Widgets.
- **Presentation Layer:** handles what users see — Pages (dashboards and layouts), Reports (list, Kanban, calendar, pivot views), and Forms (drag-and-drop data entry).
- **Application & Logic Layer:** drives the app's behaviour — the Workflow Engine for automation, Deluge Scripting for custom logic, Microservices, and Integrations (APIs, payment gateways, marketplace apps).
- **Data Layer:** stores everything — a multi-tenant Cloud Database, File & Attachment Storage, and an Audit Trail & Backup mechanism.
- **Governance & Security:** manages Users & Role-Based Access, Security Policies/MFA, Organization Settings, and Domains/Active Directory.
- **Deployment & Lifecycle:** moves an app from build to release through a Stage Environment, Production Environment, Version History/Publish, and Mobile Rebranding/Distribution.
- **Monitoring & Administration:** wraps around the whole stack, providing Metrics & Analytics, an Operations Console (logs, audit, backup), and Billing & Subscription Management.

Zoho Creator Platform Architecture

Layered, low-code architecture from access to deployment

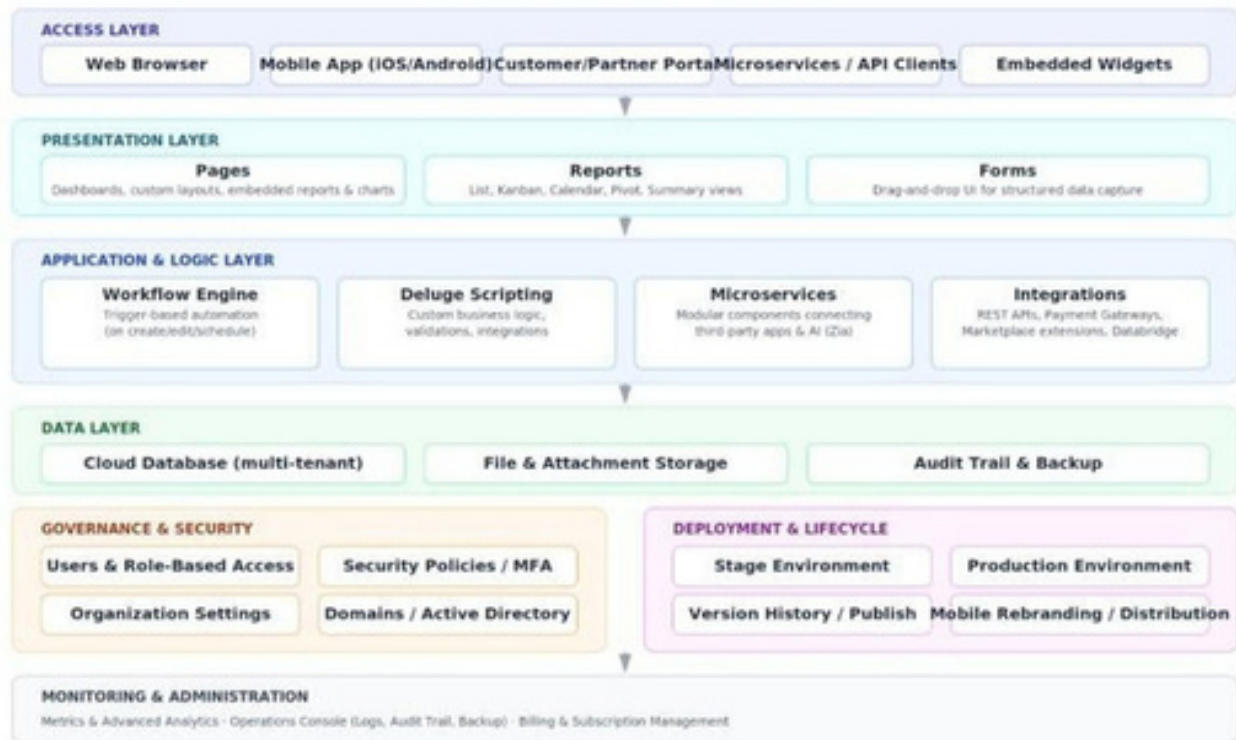


Figure: Zoho Creator's layered platform architecture, from user access through to deployment

1. Application Dashboard

- Loads automatically right after sign-in, under the Develop menu.
- Each card on this screen represents a Solution — a full business application built within the account.
- Any sample apps already present in the account appear here.
- The “Create Application” button, in the top-right corner, is where building a new app begins.

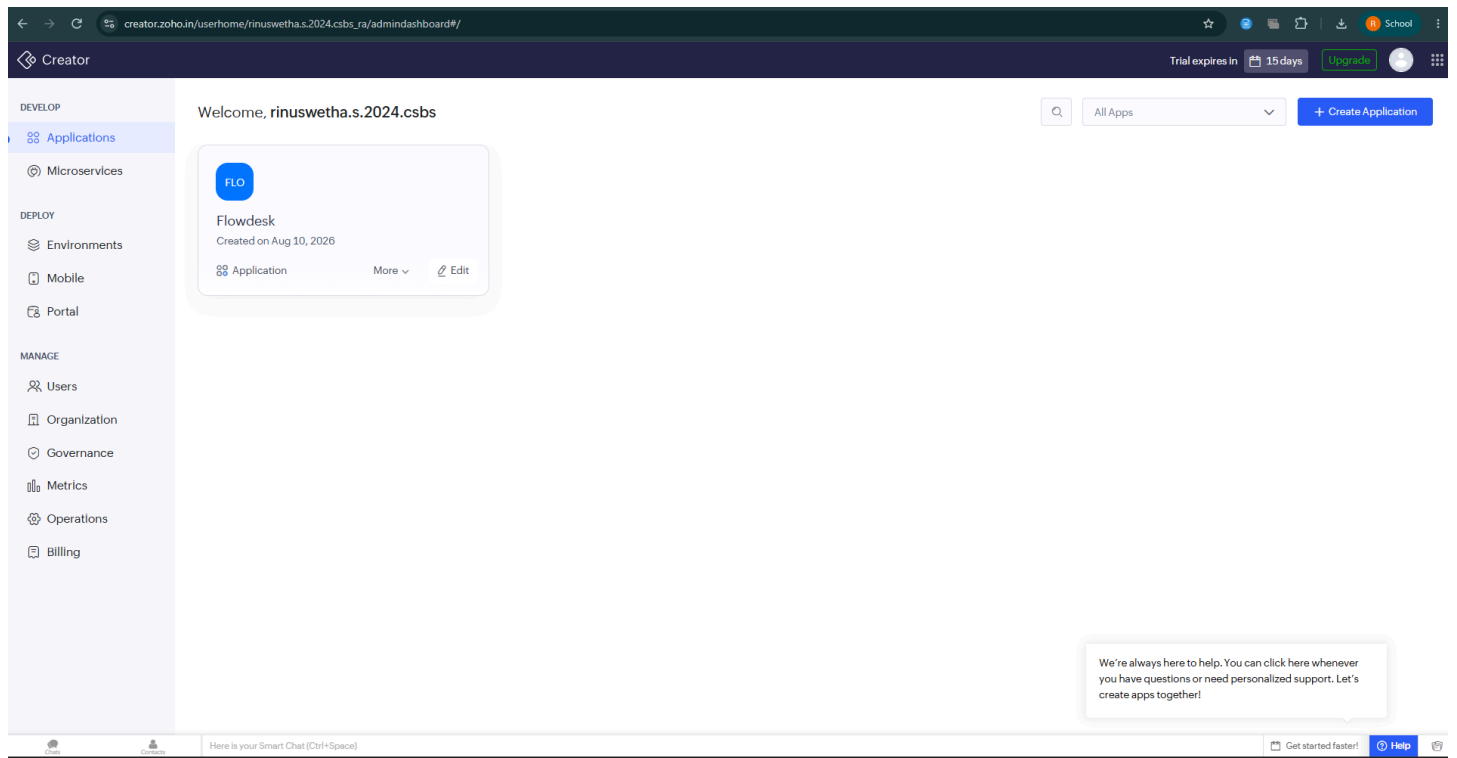


Figure 1: The Application Dashboard in Zoho Creator

2. Microservices

- Also located under Develop; the screen appears empty until at least one microservice has been created.
- A Microservice is a small, self-contained, reusable piece of backend logic — for instance, a shared tax-calculation routine or an authentication check.
- It can be invoked from several different Solutions, avoiding the need to rebuild the same logic repeatedly.
- The concept is comparable to a function library in conventional programming: build it once and reuse it wherever needed.
- Since microservices live outside any single Solution, they are managed independently — created, updated, and versioned without touching the apps that consume them.
- Common use cases include shared validation rules, third-party API wrappers, notification triggers, and utility functions like currency conversion or date formatting.
- Zia, Zoho's built-in AI, can be called from a microservice, letting several apps tap into the same intelligent feature without duplicating configuration.
- Because a microservice has its own execution context, updating its logic instantly reflects across every Solution that calls it, with no redeployment of the parent apps required.
- This modular approach keeps large, multi-app accounts easier to maintain, since fixes and improvements are made in a single place rather than repeated across projects.

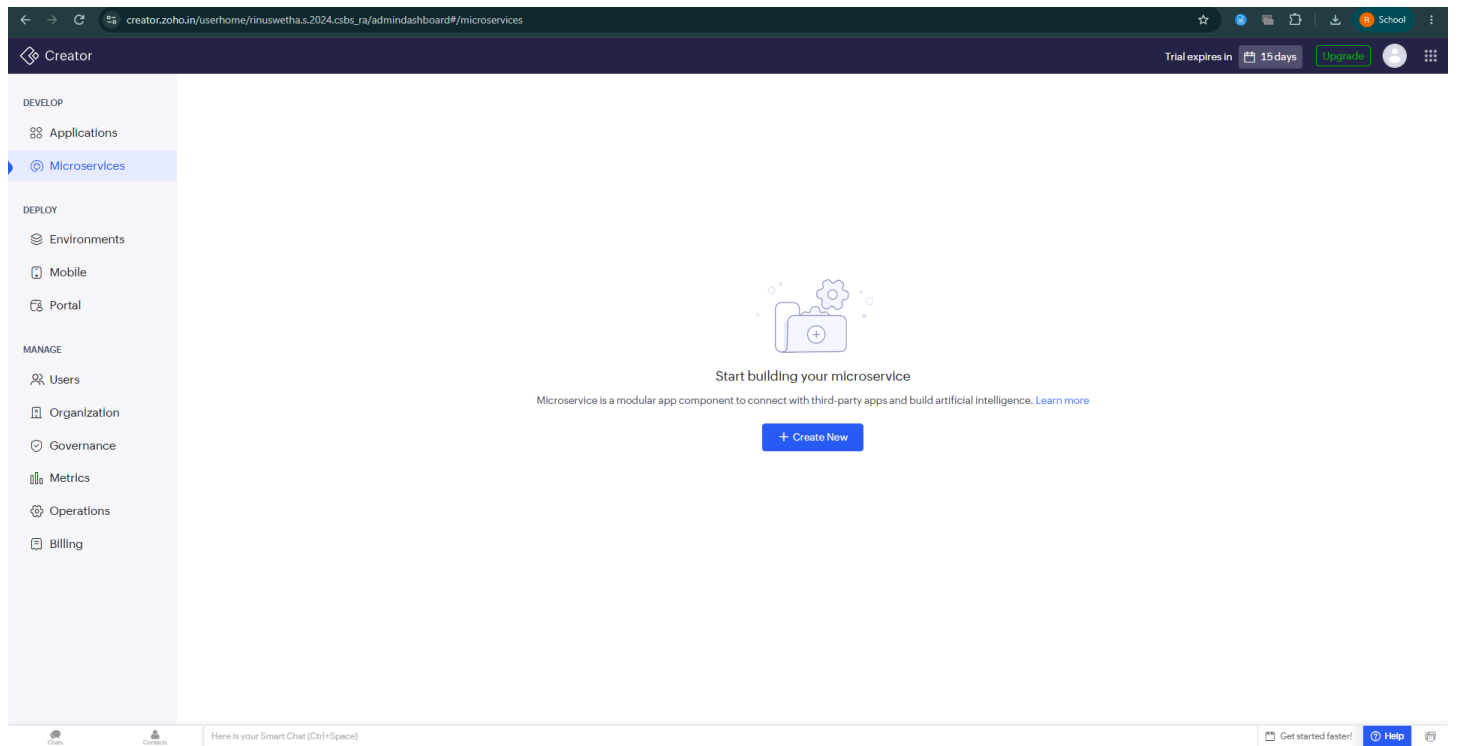


Figure 2: The Microservices screen in Zoho Creator

3. Environments

- Located under Deploy, this screen organises an application's lifecycle into distinct stages.
- **Two primary environments:** Stage, used for testing, and Production, the live environment used by real users.
- In short: Development is where features are actively built, Stage is where the app gets verified, and Production is the version end users interact with.
- Keeping these environments separate stops unfinished work from disrupting real users.

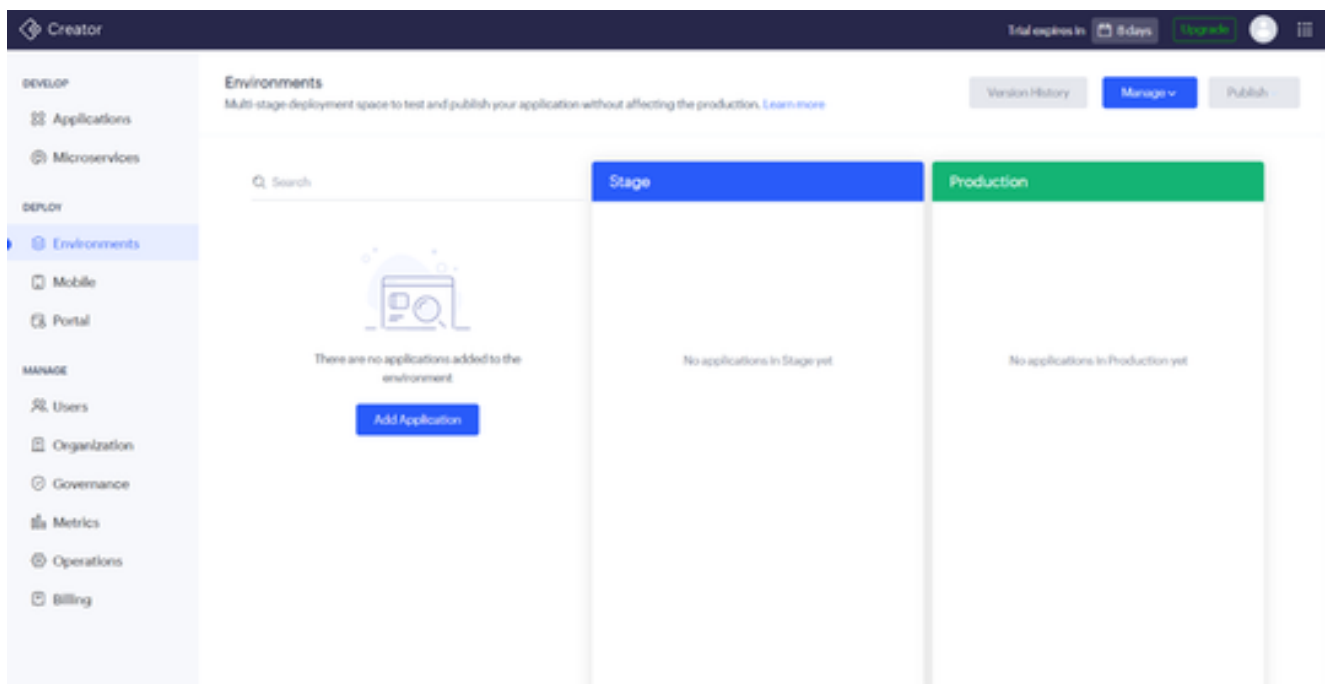


Figure 3: The Environments screen in Zoho Creator

4. Mobile

- Another piece of the Deploy stage; it automatically reshapes an app's layout to fit phones and tablets, so no separate mobile build is required.
- Accounts can download the app as a rebranded mobile application or distribute it through the Play Store/App Store, though this requires an account upgrade.
- Mobile access is essentially an extension of the same application rather than a separate rebuild.

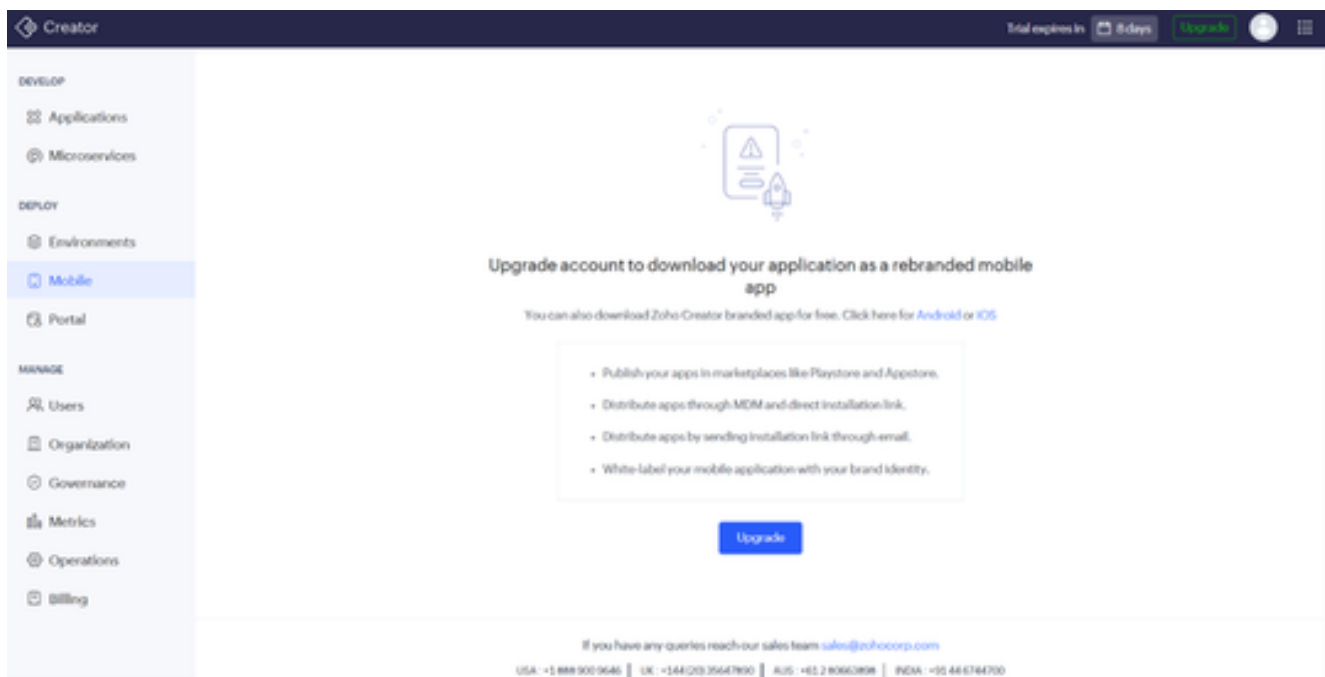


Figure 4: The Mobile screen in Zoho Creator

5. Portal

- The third component of the Deploy stage.
- A Portal opens a controlled, branded window into the application for external users — customers, vendors, or the general public.
- It does not expose internal data or the full administrative interface.
- The “Create Now” option is the starting point for setting up this external-facing access.
- Portals are commonly used for customer self-service — order tracking, support ticket submission, or invoice downloads — without granting access to the underlying Solution.
- Each portal can carry its own branding, including logo and colour scheme, so it feels like a dedicated site rather than an extension of the internal admin tool.
- Access to a portal is controlled separately from internal users, so external visitors only ever see the specific forms and reports an administrator chooses to expose.
- Portals can scale to a large number of external users, since Zoho Creator distinguishes between internal users, who consume licenses, and portal users, who typically don't.
- Setting one up generally involves selecting the pages to expose, configuring the sign-in method,

and applying a custom domain if branding needs to go a step further.

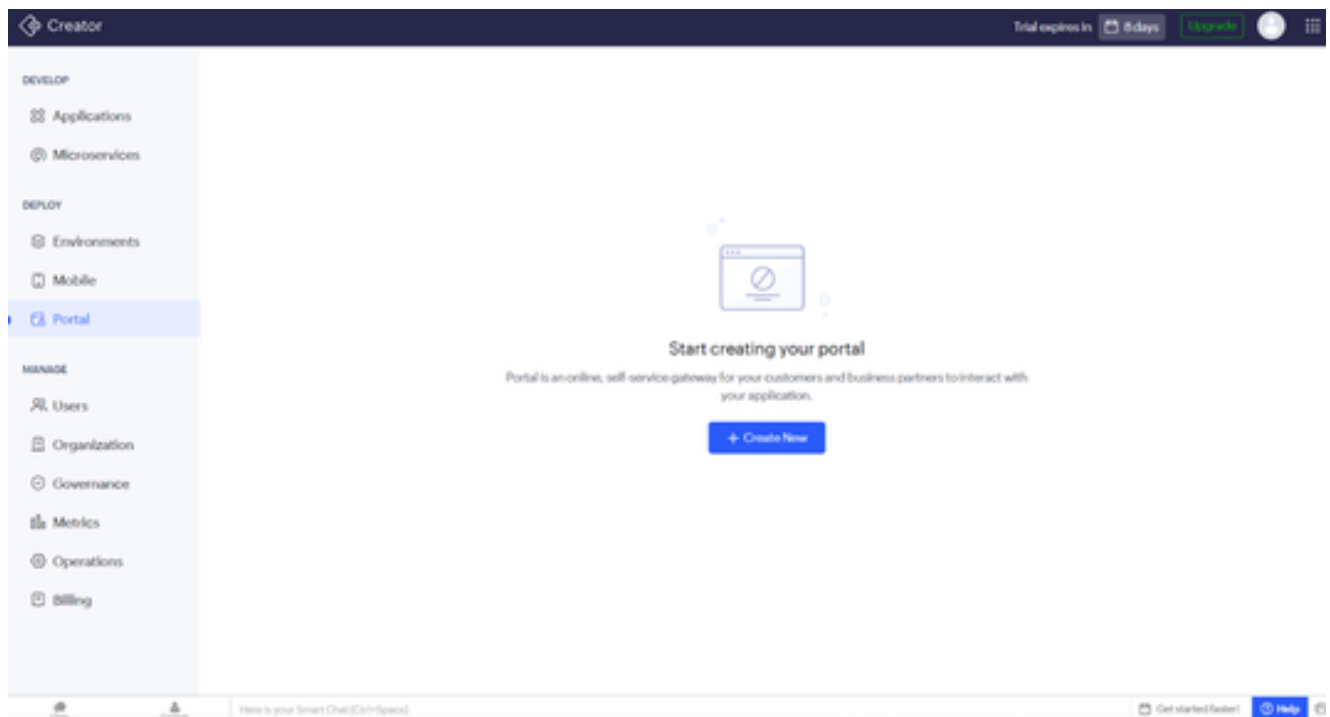


Figure 5: The Portal screen in Zoho Creator

6. Users

- The first screen you see under the Manage section.
- It lists everyone who has access to the account — for example, the account owner appears here as an active user.
- Administrators can use this screen to add or remove users and to assign roles and permissions that govern access.

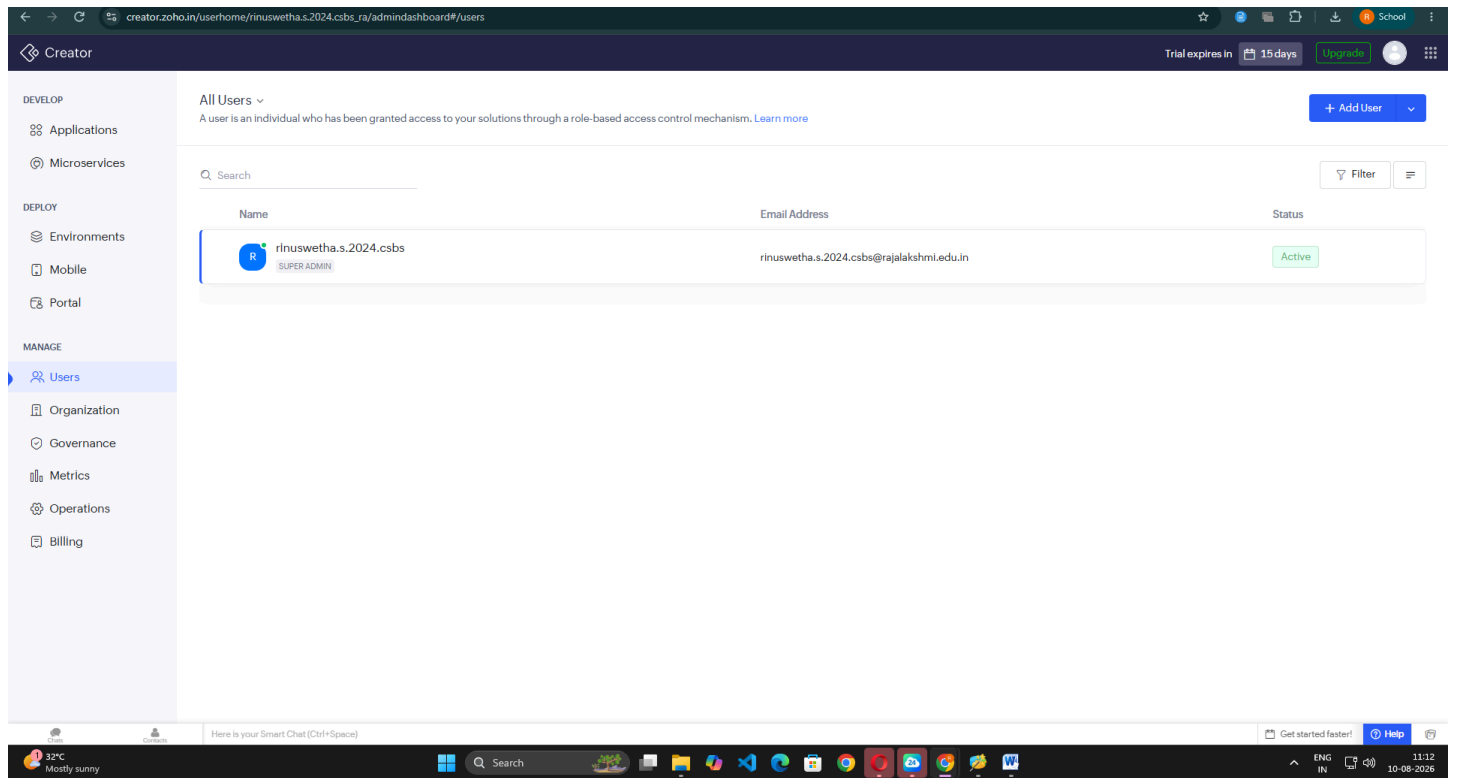


Figure 6: The Users screen in Zoho Creator

7. Organization

- Stores account-wide details such as the company logo, favicon, and contact information.
- Also holds super-admin details, including email address and phone number.
- Preferences here include the organization's subdomain and time zone.
- Together, these settings define the account's identity at a level separate from any single application.

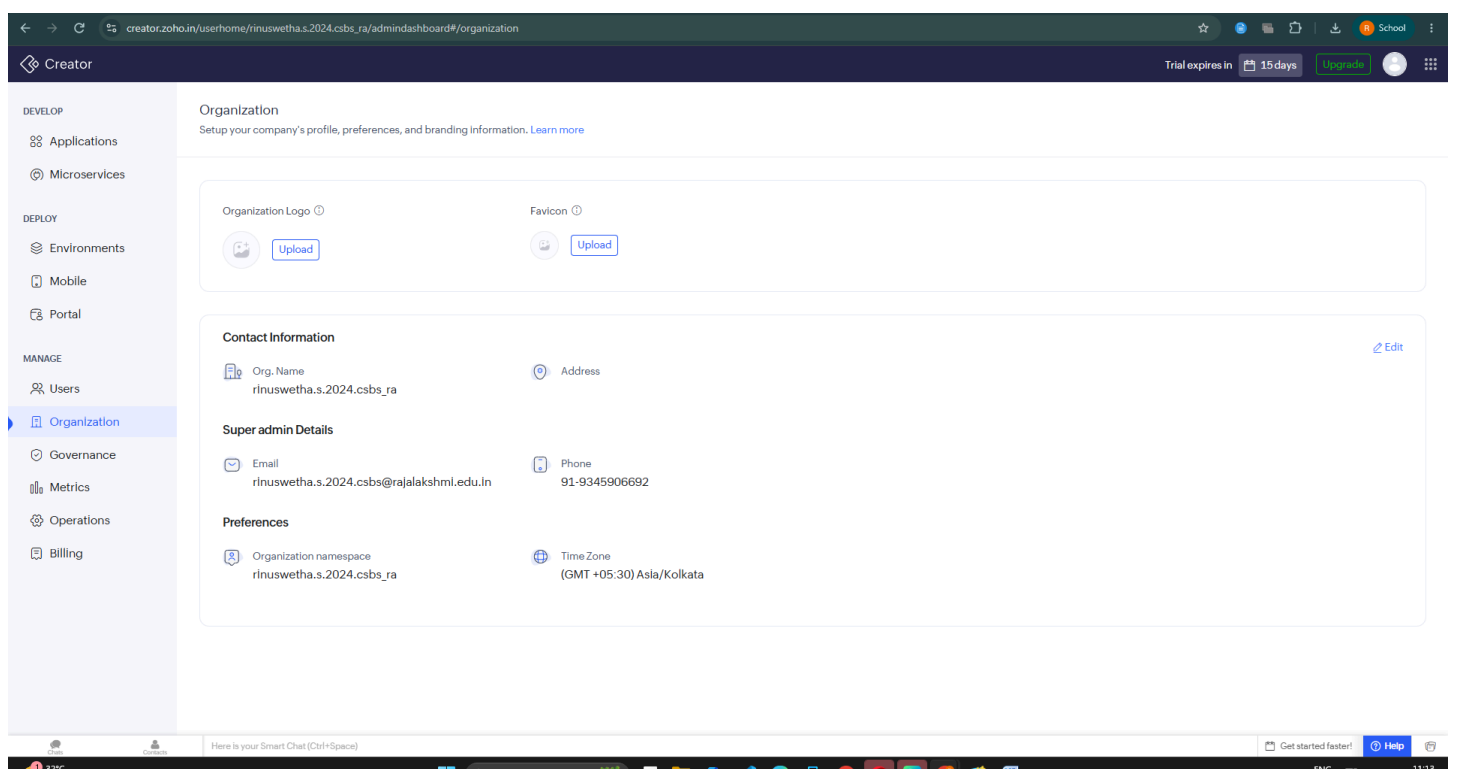


Figure 7: The Organization screen in Zoho Creator

8. Governance

- Used to set compliance rules, data policies, and audit controls for the entire account.
- The Security Policies tab lets administrators configure settings — such as password rules and multi-factor authentication — that apply across every application.
- This keeps data handling and access practices consistent as the account grows.

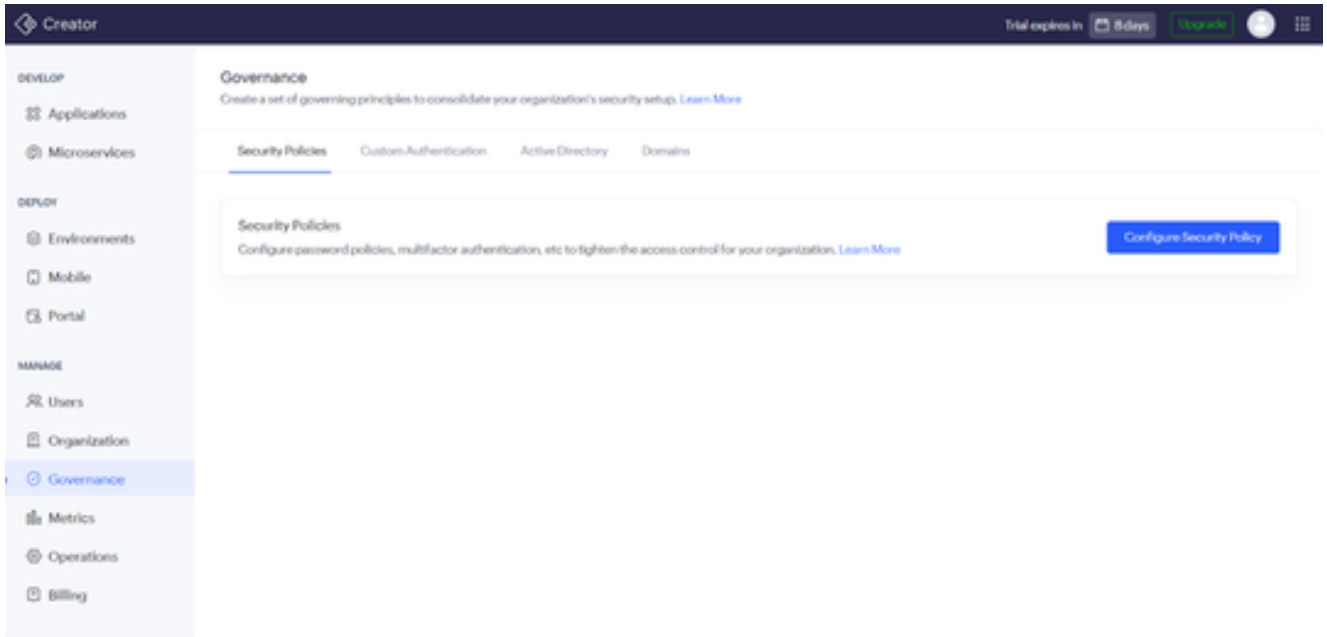


Figure 8: The Governance screen in Zoho Creator

9. Metrics

- Tracks usage statistics such as the number of applications accessed, how many apps are live, and the average daily hits per application.
- Includes charts covering application access trends and overall usage summaries.
- Gives administrators ongoing visibility into adoption and performance.

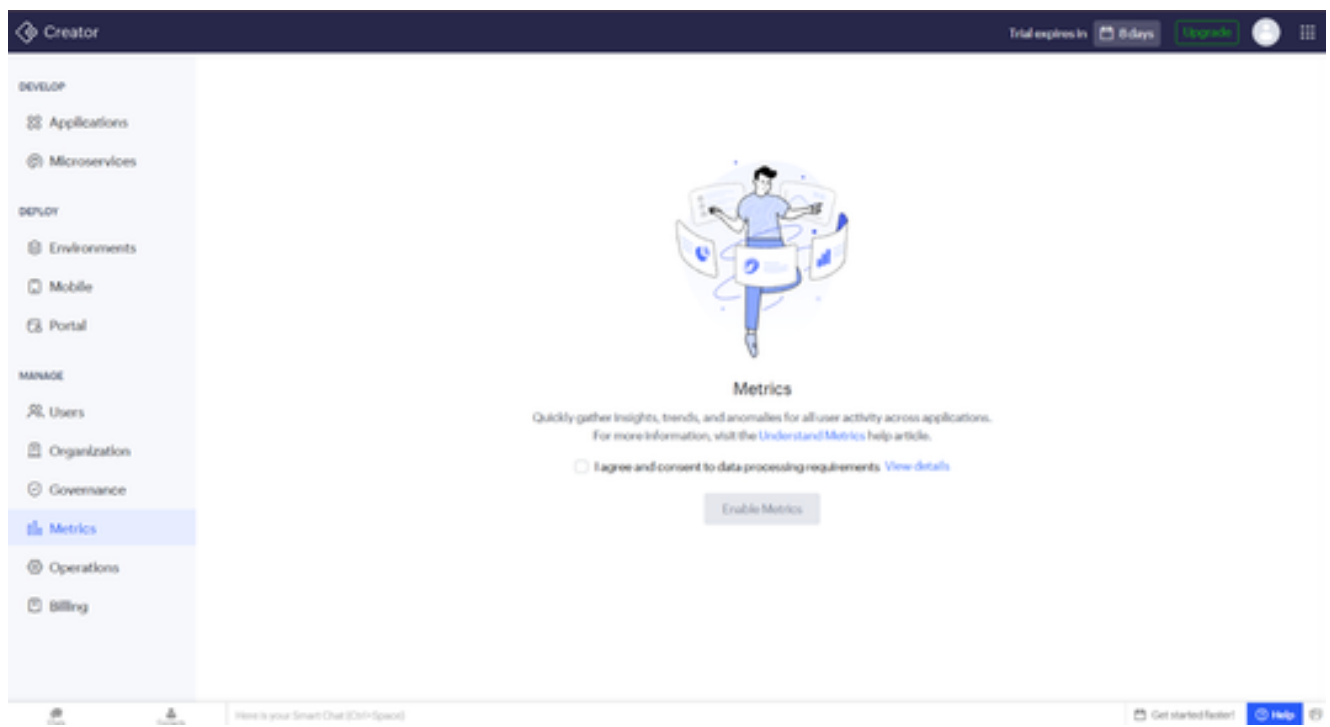


Figure 9: The Metrics screen in Zoho Creator

10. Operations

- Houses advanced, behind-the-scenes management tools, grouped under Applications.
- Covers backup, audit trail, domain restriction, API management, logs, publish settings, form email, and more.
- Also extends to support access, system integrations, Zia (AI), payment gateways, and marketplace tools.
- Effectively, this is the control centre for keeping applications running smoothly.
- The Backup option lets administrators schedule or trigger manual backups of application data, which is useful before major changes or migrations.
- Audit Trail keeps a chronological record of who changed what within the account, which is valuable for troubleshooting and for meeting compliance requirements.
- API Management issues and revokes API keys, letting external systems interact with an application programmatically while keeping access controlled.
- Domain Restriction limits sign-in to specific email domains, a simple way to keep an account's user base confined to a known organization.
- Because all of these tools sit in one place, administrators don't need to hunt through individual Solutions to manage account-wide operational settings.

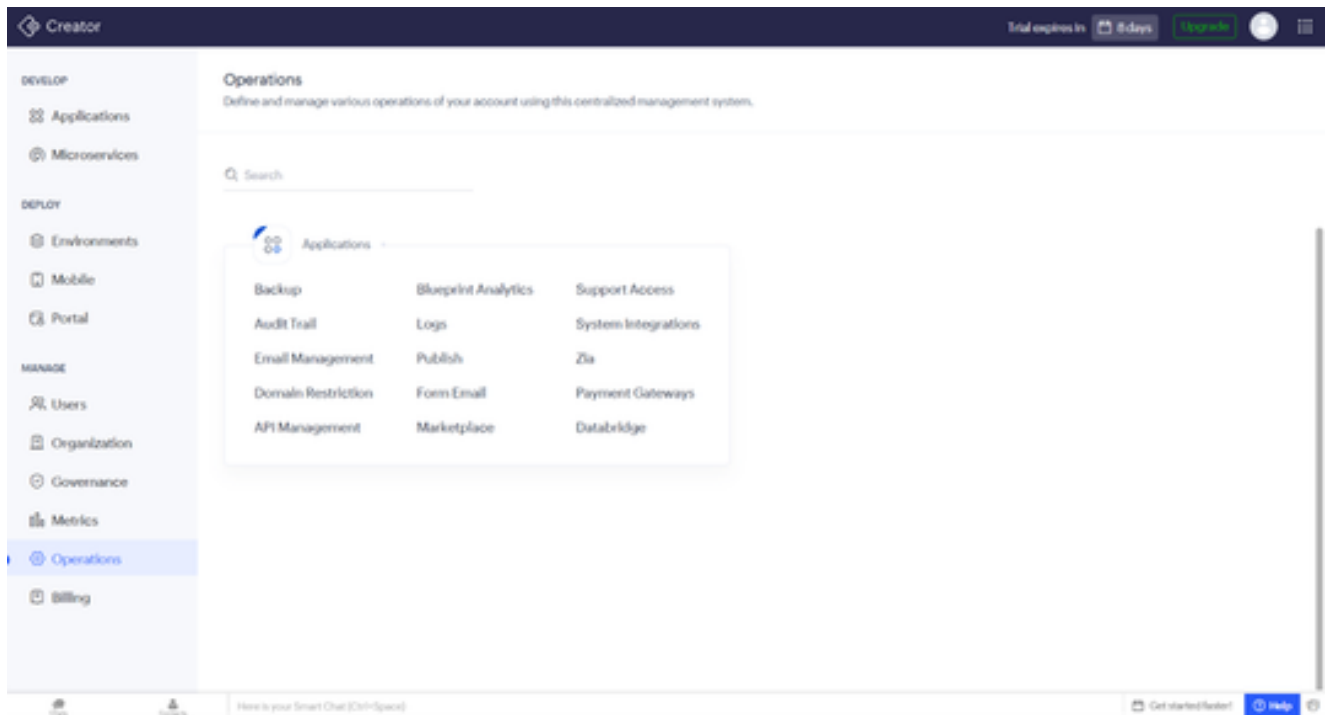
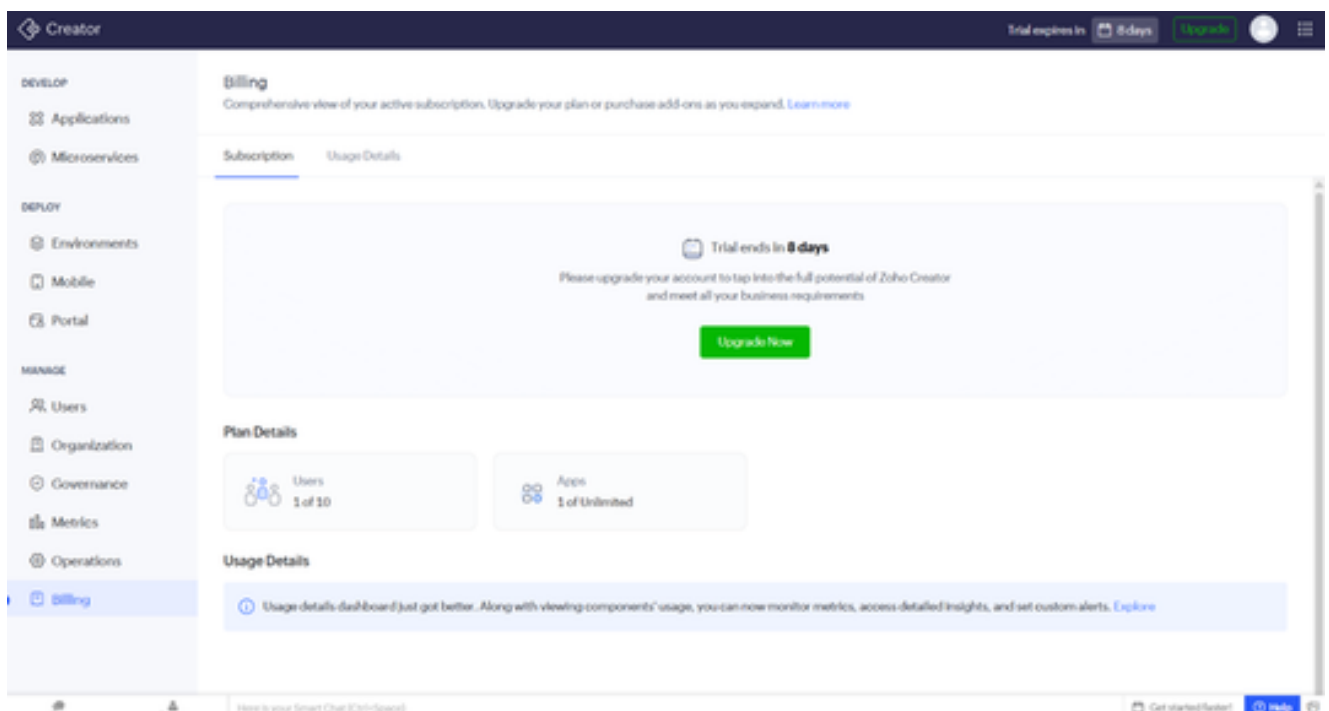


Figure 10: The Operations screen in Zoho Creator

11. Billing

- Provides a full overview of the account's active subscription.
- Displays plan details, such as user and app limits, along with an option to upgrade.
- The Usage Details section tracks component-level usage, metrics, and custom alerts.
- A useful final checkpoint for confirming what the account currently includes and where action may be needed.



Conclusion

- This exploration covered Zoho Creator's account setup along with its three core functional areas.
- **Develop** (Applications, Microservices) — where an app's forms, logic, and reusable components come together.
- **Deploy** (Environments, Mobile, Portal) — governs how the finished app gets released and shared.
- **Manage** (Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Billing) — covers the ongoing administrative work.
- Taken together, these three areas trace the full lifecycle of a low-code application — from the first build through to everyday operation.
- The overall account structure reinforces a clean separation of concerns: building logic, releasing it safely, and administering it day-to-day are each handled by dedicated screens rather than being mixed together.
- One notable takeaway is how little of the platform actually requires code — most of what was explored here (layouts, environments, users, security policies) is configured through forms and toggles rather than scripts.
- The Stage/Production split under Environments stood out as a practical safeguard, since it means new features can be verified thoroughly before they ever reach a real user.
- Microservices and the Portal feature both illustrate the same underlying idea — building something once and exposing it safely to many consumers, whether those consumers are other apps or external users.
- The Manage section, though it can feel administrative, is really where an account's long-term health is decided — user access, governance rules, and billing all live here.
- Metrics and Operations together give administrators the visibility and the controls needed to keep applications healthy well after the initial build is finished.
- For a newcomer, the guided walkthrough format made the platform considerably less intimidating — pairing each screenshot with a short explanation kept the focus on what a feature does rather than every menu option available.
- A logical next step beyond this exploration would be to actually build a small Solution end-to-end — a form, a couple of reports, and one workflow rule — to see these pieces work together in practice.
- Overall, this walkthrough offers a solid foundation for understanding how a modern low-code platform is organised, and it sets up the next stage of hands-on application building with confidence.
- The exercise also highlighted how the same account can support very different kinds of users at once — internal builders, administrators, and external portal visitors — each seeing only what is relevant to them.
- Screens like Governance and Organization made it clear that low-code does not mean low-oversight; security policies, access rules, and audit trails are all still first-class citizens of the platform.
- The Mobile screen was a useful reminder that responsive design is handled automatically here, which removes an entire category of work that would otherwise need a separate mobile build.
- Billing rounded things out by tying every earlier screen back to real account limits — a practical closing point, since even the best-designed application still runs within a defined plan.
- In summary, this account setup walkthrough moved from first sign-in, through the architecture that ties every layer together, to the day-to-day realities of running a live low-code application.